After

By Carol K. Mack

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS PLAYING GLYNDA *– BACK TO AUDIENCE – VOICE OF A TOUR BUS DRIVER: (Voiceover.) Right over here, folks! That's all, folks! Let's go ... time's up. Back on the bus now, boys and girls, we've got lots more to see! Hi! Step right up ... Hi there. How're ya doin' ... everybody here? Aaalll aboard! ... Hello? ExCUSE me, Miss. HEY, you over there? Hello?! We're boarding ... Lady?! Hey, you can't go over there! Ma'am ... Nobody's allowed over there ... HEY! Hey you, get back here! Somebody get that visitor. She's off-limits! GET HER! GET HER! (Turns to Audience for Intro)*

ACTRESS PLAYING CINDY: *(Out of Breath) – Holy cow! You would not believe this. One minute I'm all goo-goo eyes over my fiancée and the next minute, I'm compelled to investigate the most amazing thing I've ever seen! Who said coming to Disney World was for kids? This is where most fairy tales end. The prince and princess marry and ride off into the sunset to begin their new life together as husband and wife, a life full of promise, romance, and above all, love.*

ACTRESS PLAYING GLYNDA: *Shhhh! Everything will be fine . . . Just stay calm . . . Not everyone knows the truth about the fairy tale endings . . . Happily Ever After . . . is kept a closely guarded secret. At least the "AFTER" part.*

TOGETHER: *After by Carol K. Mack*

CINDY: *(Awestruck, looks out to back of house.)* Oh! ... WHOA! *(Lowers her sun- glasses, removes cap.)* What the ...

GLYNDA: *(Sweetly, out of breath.)* There you are!

CINDY: Where?!

GLYNDA: *(Graciously.)* Off-limits, I fear, but ...

CINDY: What *is* this *place?*

GLYNDA: Please come with me now, dear.

CINDY: *(Grabs Glynda's wrist, points to rear of house.)* What's that?!

GLYNDA: What ... ?

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CINDY: Who *are* they?

GLYNDA: Come along, please?

CINDY: They're all over the grass!

GLYNDA: It's not real grass, it's ... (all right)

CINDY: Allover!

GLYNDA: This isn't part of the tour.

CINDY: As far as the eye can see!

GLYNDA: It's not for visitors ...

CINDY: *(Confrontational.)* Why not? Why is it "not for visitors"?

GLYNDA: *(Whispering.)* He wouldn't like it.

CINDY: Who?

GLYNDA: Mr. Walt.

CINDY: Walt. .. ? *(Peering at Glynda.)* But he's ...

GLYNDA: Yes! But he still *cares.*

CINDY: *(Is she crazy?)* Oh yeah?

GLYNDA: He doesn't like our visitors to be unhappy. Look how upset you're getting. And for what?

CINDY: For what?! You see them? There must be *hundreds* of white horses ...

GLYNDA: This is an unscheduled stop and we must disclaim any ...

CINDY: *(Finally realizing.) This* is where they all wind up, isn't it?

GLYNDA: *(Simply, Glynda the Good.)* Oh my, oh my, oh my.

CINDY: And all of those couples were princes and ...

GLYNDA: *Are* princes. Are! We can't *have* this!

CINDY: *(Into her recorder, a reporter.)* Hundreds of white horses have fallen here along with their riders and they're all gorgeous!

GLYNDA: Oh no!

CINDY: The women are dressed up in *(Squinting.) prom* dresses. Many have blond braids.

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GLYNDA: *(Aghast.)* You're a journalist!

CINDY: All the guys are hunks in helmets ...

GLYNDA: Forget you saw this please, for your own sake! For your *species!*

CINDY: *(Into recorder)* They all appear to be smiling expectantly, as if. ..

GLYNDA: It had to end! Try to understand, it had to end!

CINDY: *(Childlike anger.)* WHY?! It says Happily Ever After!

GLYNDA: *(Brightly)* That's *right,* dear!

CINDY: That's RIGHT?!

GLYNDA: *(With a sweeping gesture accompanied by stardust)* Why yes! This *is* Happily Ever After.

CINDY: This is IT? A dump site!? *(To her recorder darkly.)* They're all just *lying* there, thick as penguins, far as the eye can see.

GLYNDA: But happily.

CINDY: You call that happily!?

GLYNDA: Goodness, yes. They're just ... *(A rainbow gesture.)* Over.

CINDY: That's not *fair. (Cindy unexpectedly bursts into tears)*

GLYNDA: Go ahead and cry if it makes you feel better! *(Glynda hands Cindy a twinkling handkerchief)*

CINDY: *(Crying.)* It's ... I always thought that *after* was only the Beginning. I thought they'd go a long way after After!

GLYNDA: Oh dear, I know. But you see nothing was written for them.

CINDY: What?

GLYNDA: Just, "The End."

CINDY: *(Explosively ranting.)* That's not fair! After they worked so hard? With the *moats* and the *dragons* and the *towers* and hacking through bramble with *witches* flying after them and does the slipper fit or doesn't it and then *finally* it's all okay and what!? They wind up sprawled all over some stupid theme park in

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Florida!? That is sick!

GLYNDA: *(Beat, then lamely.)* It's sunny. *(At Cindy's look.)* And you can see they're all quite ... content.

CINDY: Forty acres of horses and lovers ... *(Thought, turns dismayed to Glynda.)* Oh no! I bet they didn't even ... (get a chance.)

GLYNDA: Into the sunset! Hoof beats, anticipation! A brief and shining moment. En route. It does keep them smiling. Forever. *(Lamely.)* Jellybean?

CINDY: I just lost my appetite.

GLYNDA: This isn't an easy job for me either, being a part-time guide here!

CINDY: ... You're an actress?

GLYNDA: A fairy.

CINDY: *(Flatly)* A fairy.

GLYNDA: An unemployed fairy.

CINDY: Oh yeah?

GLYNDA: You couldn't tell?

CINDY: No, actually, I never met one before.

GLYNDA: SO you think!

CINDY: Right. Do I get three wishes or what?

GLYNDA: That's *genies!* That's what I mean! Fairies are completely misunderstood and it's impossible to find work. A tooth here, a tooth there ... *We* are the endangered species nobody talks about. Children ignore our random acts of kindness. Cynics abound. Our forests are cut down and we have nowhere left to go. There are horrible waves in the air from your new-fangled inventions! Oh, how we used to dance to the music of the wind-up Victrola as it wafted gently to the bottom of the garden. And now? We get struck down by words flying through the ether like arrows! "You've got mail!" A million times a night! And what does it *mean* anyhow? *(Disdainfully.)* And the New Age?

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They've got their angels and their channels but what about us? Nobody cares. You think *you're* disillusioned? I'm disenchanted! I wish I could cry. Fairies can't cry you know. Of course you don't know! Why would you? *(Breaking down.)* Now all I can get is "After!" And it's not even supposed to *exist.* It's strictly OffLimits ... after all these millennia, I'm NOWHERE!

CINDY: I'm really sorry...I don't know what to *say* ... *(Looks at her uniform ID tag.)* "Glynda." Should I clap? Would that help?

GLYNDA: That doesn't work. Applause and barking and car horns all scare us to death. And by the way, we hate caraway seeds.

CINDY: Oh. Then, well what can I do?

GLYNDA: Just make up your mind! *(A puzzled look, pointedly.)* Before you get back to the Bus.

CINDY: *(Jolted back to reality.)* Bus.

GLYNDA: *(Coaching.)* Your beau on the Bus?

CINDY: Oh ... *(Remembering problem.)* Him. Right.

GLYNDA: Yes *him!* That was why you wandered off, wasn't it?

CINDY: Yeah, I guess it was ... It's such a big commitment! I mean I don't know if! can go through with it. I just ...

GLYNDA: You must decide!

CINDY: Well, if this is Happily Ever After, you know what you can do with it!

GLYNDA: Well, if you've decided against a wedding celebration, I'll just fade out now.

CINDY: Wait! I, I didn't say that. All I said was I don't *know* ...

GLYNDA: Tell me: Does he have a horse?

CINDY: *(With grudging belief)* No, they don't ride horses anymore, Glynda.

GLYNDA: *(Wistfully.)* Things change.

CINDY: Yes!

GLYNDA: But fairies don't. Neither do fairy tales. *(Tiny ping sound.)*

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CINDY: *(At ping, small smile.)* ... He's got a Jeep Wrangler.

GLYNDA: Ah. *(Tiny ping sound.)*

CINDY: It was really mine and I sold it to him. That's how we met. See I was selling my car to finance a trip to Nepal, and this guy shows up to buy it and then, we wound up going trekking together and, he's really, uh ... *(Doesn't say "great," but her recall is positive, romantic)* He's ... we've got a lot in common and ... y'know he's a journalist too .. .in fact, he's covering this place ... I mean not *this!* *(Stops abruptly, staring at field, realizing.)* So, you gotta write your own After. That's the deal, huh?

GLYNDA: Exactly!

CINDY: *(Gesturing to field.)* It's gotta be better than ...

GLYNDA: *It* could be!

CINDY: *(Getting her point.)* Yeah ... It *could be* anything! Right?

GLYNDA: Right! *(small ping.)*

CINDY: Thank you! You know what? I want to go back now!

GLYNDA: Good! *(As Cindy turns)* But you can't take anything with you.

CINDY: What do you mean?!

GLYNDA: Memory. We can't let you ...

CINDY: Look, I swear I won't print this story, okay?

GLYNDA: It's too dangerous. It would end your species.

CINDY: Okay, okay, but you can't make me forget!

GLYNDA: Don't force me to do anything unkind.

CINDY: Now what are you, a *hit* fairy?

GLYNDA: *(Touches Cindy with wand, immediate effect. Cindy freezes in place. Casts spell with wand.)* Now, forget this field and all tale-spinning, the horse, and all the princes grinning. Forget The End and make a *new* beginning! Forget the pumpkins, the mice, and all witchcraft, forget it all in love and laughter. Forget, and keep

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your dream of After. *(Ping.)*

CINDY: *(Opens her eyes, slight disorientation.)* Hello? ... I thought I... Excuse me? Where's the bus!?

GLYNDA: It worked! *There* you are, we were just getting worried about you. I'm your tour guide, Glynda?

CINDY: Don't I know you from ... ?

GLYNDA: The Bus. We must hurry. There's a nice young man on line who's waiting for you ...

CINDY: *(Face brightens.)* Oh yeah, *him!* We're getting *married* this weekend!

GLYNDA: How lovely! I'll be there ... *(Correcting her slip.)* in spirit.

CINDY: *(Disoriented.)* I feel like, like I forgot something.

GLYNDA: Like a toothbrush? Here. I carry extras.

CINDY: Thanks ... Did you see a tape recorder anywhere?

GLYNDA: Is this yours? *(Handing her recorder with tape dangling.)* I think it. .. dropped.

CINDY: *(Shaking her head.)* I'm feeling kinda weird.

GLYNDA: *(Steering her away from site)* Probably something you ate in the cafeteria. Did you eat an apple? Don't worry it's just a spell. .. Now what did you say your name was?

CINDY: Cindy? *(As they exit)*

GLYNDA: Cindy! Ah, I knew a Cindy once upon a time, long, long ago ...

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AWARD HISTORY

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